



Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church Sunday School Department
Mahibere Kidusan North America Center
Campus Ministry

In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit . One God, Amen!

Dogmatic Theology

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Semester 2



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Mystery of Incarnation



Mystery of Incarnation

- What is Incarnation?
- Incarnation in the New Testament and in the Old Testament
- Why Incarnation?
- What we benefited from the Incarnation of the Son of God.



Mystery of Incarnation

- ❖ The teaching that one of the three persons of the Trinity, God the Son, came down from heaven and was made man by partaking of our nature from the Virgin Mary.
 - ❖ He descended and dwelt in the Virgin's womb without reduction from above and without addition from below.
 - ❖ He partook of our nature from the Virgin Mary and dwelt in her womb for five months and five days, and was born of her without changing her Virginity.
 - ❖ He was incarnate of the Virgin Mary without mixture and without division.
 - ❖ He is perfectly Divine and perfectly human without sin.
 - ❖ He is one nature of two natures.



Mystery of Incarnation

❖ Prophecies about Incarnation

- ❖ *“And I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your seed and her Seed: He shall bruise your head. “**Gen. 3:15***
- ❖ *“Behold a virgin shall conceive and bear a Son, and shall call His name Immanuel. **Is. 7:14***
- ❖ *“For unto us a child is born; unto us a Son is given; and the government will be upon His shoulder. And His name will be called Wonderful, Counselor, Mighty God, everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.” (**Isaiah 9:6**).*
- ❖ *“Your father Abraham rejoiced to see My day and He saw it and was glad.” (**John 8:56; Gen. 22**)*



Mystery of Incarnation

❖ Incarnation in the New Testament

- ❖ *"In the beginning was the Word, the Word was with God, and the Word was God . . . The same was in the beginning with God. All things were made by Him, and without Him was not anything made that was made . . . And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, full of grace and truth, and we beheld His glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father."***(John 1:1-14)**
- ❖ *"And we know that the Son of God has come and has given us an understanding, that we may know Him who is true; and we are in Him who is true, in His Son Jesus Christ. This is the true God and eternal life."***(1 John 5:20)**
- ❖ *"I am the Alpha and the Omega, the Beginning and the End," says the Lord, "who is and who was and who is to come, the Almighty."***(Revelation 1:8)**
- ❖ *"And without controversy, great is the mystery of Godliness: **God was manifest in the flesh...**"***(1 Tim. 3:16)**
- ❖ *"By this you know the Spirit of God: every spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God."***(1 John 4:2)**
- ❖ *"Now all this took place to fulfill what was spoken of **the Lord** through the prophet: Behold a virgin shall conceive and bear a Son, and shall call His name Immanuel, which translated means God with us."***(Matt. 1:22-23)**



Mystery of Incarnation

❖ Why Incarnation?

- ❖ God in His essence is perfectly loving and perfectly just
 - ❖ Because He is perfectly loving He couldn't just let Adam die and perish
 - ❖ Because He is perfectly just Adam and Eve had to die because of their sin

"It would, of course, have been unthinkable that God should go back upon His word and that man, having transgressed, should not die; but it was equally monstrous that beings which once had shared the nature of the Word should perish and turn back again into non-existence through corruption.

"It was unworthy of the goodness of God that creatures made by Him should be brought to nothing through the deceit wrought upon man by the devil; and it was supremely unfitting that the work of God in mankind should disappear, either through their own negligence or through the deceit of evil spirits..."

"Men had turned from the contemplation of God above, and were looking for Him in the opposite direction, down among created things and things of sense. The Savior of us all, the Word of God, in His great love took to Himself a body and moved as Man among men, meeting their senses, so to speak" /St. Athanasius, On the Incarnation/



Mystery of Incarnation

- ❖ "The wages of sin is death." (Romans 6:23).
- ❖ Who can regenerate the human soul and spirit?

❖ Characteristics of the Redeemer

❖ Must be a human being

"For since by man came death, by man came also the resurrection of the dead. Just as in Adam all die, even so in Christ shall all be made alive," /1 Cor. 15:21-22/

*"... There was a debt owing which must needs be paid; for, as I said before, all men were due to die. Here, then, is the second reason why the Word dwelt among us, ... **He might offer the sacrifice on behalf of all, surrendering His own temple to death in place of all, to settle man's account with death and free him from the primal transgression.** In the same act also He showed Himself mightier than death, displaying His own body incorruptible as the first-fruits of the resurrection. /St. Athanasius, On the Incarnation/*

"Because in the wisdom of God the world in its wisdom knew not God, God thought fit through the simplicity of the News proclaimed to save those who believe." /1 Cor. 1:21/



Mystery of Incarnation

❖ Must be infinite

“they had in their sinning surpassed all limits...”

“Thus it happened that two opposite marvels took place at once: the death of all was consummated in the Lord's body; yet, because the Word was in it, death and corruption were in the same act utterly abolished. Death there had to be, and death for all, so that the due of all might be paid...” /St. Athanasius, On the Incarnation/

❖ Must be without sin

❖ Must be the creator

❖ Recreating man required the intervention of the Creator Himself.

“His part it was, and His alone, both to bring again the corruptible to incorruption ... For He alone, being Word of the Father and above all, was in consequence both able to recreate all, and worthy to suffer on behalf of all.” /St. Athanasius, On the Incarnation/



Mystery of Incarnation

❖ What we benefited from the Incarnation of the Son of God.

❖ Through the Incarnation, we have come to know Him.

❖ *"Because in the wisdom of God the world in its wisdom knew not God, God thought fit through the simplicity of the News proclaimed to save those who believe." /1 Cor. 1:21/*

❖ *"For the earth shall be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord." /Habakkuk 2:14/*



Mystery of Incarnation

- ❖ *Death has been destroyed and we are renewed*
 - ❖ *“... the new man, which is renewed in knowledge after the image of Him that created him.” /Col. 3:10/*
 - ❖ *Inasmuch then as the children have partaken of flesh and blood, He Himself likewise shared in the same that through death, He might destroy Him who had the power of death...” /Heb. 2:14/*
- ❖ *We are redeemed.*
 - ❖ *“Blessed be the Lord God of Israel for He has visited and redeemed His people.” /Luke 1:68/*
 - ❖ *“Christ has redeemed us from the curse of the law, being made a curse for us...” /Gal. 3:13/*
 - ❖ *“... you were not redeemed with corruptible things... but with the precious blood of Christ.” /1 Pet. 1:18-19/*



Mystery of Incarnation

The Nature of the Incarnate Word and His Godhead

❖ Is Jesus Christ God?

- ❖ The primary topic of the Council of Nicaea

❖ How was His teaching received at the time?

- ❖ *“The Jews sought all the more to kill Him, because He not only broke the Sabbath, but also said that God was His Father, making Himself equal with God.” /John 5:18/*
- ❖ *“Who is this who speaks blasphemies? Who can forgive sins but God alone?” /Luke 5:21/*
- ❖ *“For a good work, we do not stone you, but for blasphemy, and You being a Man, make yourself God.” /John 10:33/*



Mystery of Incarnation

The Nature of the Incarnate Word and His Godhead

- ❖ How was His teaching received at the time?
 - ❖ *“In the beginning **was the Word, the Word was with God, and the Word was God** . . . The same was in the beginning with God. All things were made by Him, and without Him was not anything made that was made . . . **And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us**, full of grace and truth, and we beheld His glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father.”(John 1:1-14)*
 - ❖ *“James, a bondservant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ...” /James 1:1/*
 - ❖ *“My Lord and my God” /John 20:28/*
 - ❖ *“... being in the form of God, did not consider it robbery to be equal with God.” /Phil. 2:6/*
 - ❖ *“... According to the flesh, Christ came, who is over all, the eternally blessed God.” /Rom. 9:5/*



Mystery of Incarnation

Why did He say *“My Father is greater than I.”* /John 5:28/

- ❖ *“Being in the form of God, did not consider it robbery to be equal with God, but made Himself of **no reputation**, taking the form of a **bondservant**, and coming in the likeness of men. And being found in appearance as a man, **He humbled Himself and became obedient to the point of death**, even the death of the cross.”* /Phil. 2:6-8/

His Divinity in His Own words

- ❖ *“I and the Father are one.”* /John 10:30
- ❖ *“He who has seen Me as seen the Father... I am in the Father and the Father in Me...”* John 14:8-11
- ❖ *“I am the Alpha and the Omega, the Beginning and the End, the First and the Last.”* /John 22:13/



Mystery of Incarnation

The Creed of the Nicaean Fathers

- ❖ *We believe in one God, the Father Almighty, Maker of heaven and earth, and of all things visible and invisible. And in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, the only-begotten, **begotten** of the Father before all ages.
Light of Light; true God of true God; begotten, not made; of one essence with the Father, by whom all things were made...
He shall come again with glory to judge the living and the dead; whose Kingdom shall have no end.*



Mystery of Incarnation

One Nature of Two Natures

- ❖ *In the union of iron with fire, the iron is not changed into fire nor fire into iron. Both are united without mingling, confusion or alteration. Although this situation is not permanent in the case of iron, and here is the point of disagreement, but we only want to say that once iron is ignited with fire, it continues to retain all the properties of iron and all the properties of fire. Likewise, the nature of the Incarnate Logos is One Nature, having all the Divine characteristics and all the human as well.” /The Nature of Christ, by H.H. Pope Shenouda III/*



Mystery of Incarnation

One Nature of Two Natures

- ❖ *“... that at the name of Jesus, every knee should bow, of those in heaven and of those on earth...”*
- ❖ *“I am the First and the Last, I am He that lives, and was dead and behold, I am alive forevermore...” /Rev. 1:17,18/*
- ❖ *“Take heed to yourselves and to all the flock, among which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to shepherd the **church of God**, which **He purchased with His own blood.**”*

